

Alabama - 2026 Preseason Primer

2026 COLLEGE FOOTBALL PRESEASON PRIMER | SEC

Legend: trend - ● ↑ better · ● ↔ similar · ● ↓ worse · **assessment** - ● strong/positive · ● average/mixed/uncertain · ● weak/negative · ◆ new player or coach

1. 60-Second Briefing

Initial conclusions

Question	Answer
How good?	Top-15 underlying quality with a playoff-level defensive ceiling.
Preseason consensus	AP No. 13 (904 points) · SEC media No. 6 (1,930 points; 3 first-place votes) · SP+ No. 13
Returning production	48% (No. 90) overall · Off. 35% (No. 120) · Def. 61% (No. 35)
Primer power rating	+17.5 points vs. average FBS
Expected season	7.8 wins · most likely 8-4
Net vs. 2025	● ↓ - Slightly worse and materially less stable than the 11-win 2025 team because the offense replaces its starting QB.
Confidence	Medium-low

2026 identity: Ryan Grubb's offense enters 2026 with QB Keelon Russell as the named quarterback, a recognized receiver core led by WR Ryan Coleman-Williams and WR Lotzeir Brooks, and a line with three settled jobs but two live competitions. Kane Wommack's defense remains the more dependable side, built around an experienced secondary and a rebuilt front.

Bottom line: Alabama still has top-15 roster/model quality and a defense capable of carrying SEC contention, but 35% offensive returning production and an unproven QB make the Crimson Tide less stable than their No. 13 preseason consensus.

Beats expectations if: QB Keelon Russell turns the late-camp job win into efficient play, the rebuilt OL settles quickly, WR Noah Rogers becomes fully available, and the transfer-heavy front preserves the 2025 defensive efficiency.

Disappoints if: The offense cannot replace QB Ty Simpson, RB Jam Miller and multiple linemen fast enough, early RB/WR availability problems compress the rotation, and front-seven turnover reduces defensive disruption.

Five things to remember

- 1 QB stability:** QB Keelon Russell was named the 2026 starting quarterback on Aug. 22; the job is settled, but his lack of starting production still lowers confidence.
- 2 Returning production:** Returning production is only 48% overall (No. 90) and 35% on offense (No. 120), one of the clearest transition signals in Alabama's preseason profile.
- 3 Quarterback:** Alabama had 10 players selected in the 2026 NFL Draft, including QB Ty Simpson, OT Kady Proctor, C Parker Brailsford and WR Germie Bernard.
- 4 National baseline:** The defense remains the strongest model pillar: SP+ defense is No. 6, while S Bray Hubbard and CB Zabien Brown lead a secondary returning four projected starters.
- 5 Schedule pressure:** Georgia, at Tennessee, Texas A&M and at LSU dominate the schedule's high-leverage core; Alabama's SOS is No. 17.

2. 2025 in Context

Traditional Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Record	11-4 (8-2 SEC)	● Excellent
Scoring	29.5 PPG	● Good / above average
Total offense	367.7 YPG	● Average / mixed
Rush offense	104.1 YPG · 3.4 YPC	● Very poor
Pass efficiency	7.56 YPA · 32 TD / 5 INT	● Very good
Third downs	41.9%	● Good / above average
Scoring defense	19.2 PPG allowed	● Very good
Total defense	296.8 YPG allowed	● Elite
Rush defense	126.9 YPG · 3.7 YPC	● Good / above average
Pass defense	169.9 YPG · 6.44 YPA · 16 TD allowed	● Good / above average

The 2025 offense was much better at passing efficiency and converting downs than its total-yardage/rushing profile suggests: pass efficiency ranked No. 32 and third downs No. 46, while total offense was No. 84 and rush offense No. 125. The defense was the conventional strength, finishing No. 20 in scoring and No. 13 in total defense.

Advanced Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Opp.-adjusted offense	+7.38 · No. 16	● Very good
Off. EPA/play	+0.176 · No. 12	● Elite
Off. success rate	45.9% · No. 35	● Very good
Off. explosive-play rate	10.9% · No. 101	● Below average
Havoc allowed	13.8% · No. 48	● Good / above average
Opp.-adjusted defense	+8.73 · No. 10	● Elite
Def. EPA/play allowed	-0.174 · No. 9	● Elite
Def. success rate allowed	37.1% · No. 22	● Very good
Def. explosive-play rate allowed	9.8% · No. 23	● Very good
Havoc created	17.6% · No. 25	● Very good

Advanced-stat read: Alabama’s 2025 offense was better than the raw yardage/rushing totals imply: opponent-adjusted offense and EPA/play were top-16 even though explosive-play rate was only No. 101 and rushing output No. 125.

EPA and success rate use CFB Graphs regular-season data. Explosive rate uses regular-season non-garbage-time cfbfastR plays; explosive = 10+ yd rush or 20+ yd pass. Havoc = TFL + forced fumbles + passes defended per play. Lower is better for defensive rates and offensive havoc allowed.

3. Coaching

Role	2026 status	Quick impact
HC	Kalen DeBoer - returning	● ↔ Kalen DeBoer's return keeps the program and offensive philosophy stable.
OC / offensive play-caller	Ryan Grubb - Returning OC; offensive play-caller	● ↔ Ryan Grubb returns as the offensive play-caller, preserving game-day continuity.
DC	Kane Wommack - Returning defensive coordinator / system authority; Maurice Linguist remains co-DC/DB	● ↔ Kane Wommack remains the defensive system authority with Maurice Linguist alongside him as co-DC.

4. Key Roster Movement

Offense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ WR Noah Rogers	NC State	● ↔ Projects for a major role when healthy and raises the receiver ceiling.
◆ C Racin Delgatty	Cal Poly	● ↔ Has won the current center job.

Out	To	Loss
QB Ty Simpson	NFL (L.A. Rams), Round 1, No. 13	● ↓ The 2025 starting quarterback leaves.
OT Kadyn Proctor	NFL (Miami), Round 1, No. 12	● ↓ A first-round starting tackle departs from a line already replacing multiple veteran contributors.
C Parker Brailsford	NFL (Cleveland), Round 5, No. 146	● ↓ The starting center's departure creates a high-leverage continuity loss despite C Delgatty winning.
WR Germie Bernard	NFL (Pittsburgh), Round 2, No. 47	● ↓ A major 2025 receiving contributor exits as the new target hierarchy is rebuilt around.
RB Jam Miller	NFL (New England), Round 7, No. 245	● ↓ The major 2025 backfield contributor leaves.

Offensive net: ● ↓ Clear step back in continuity from 2025.

Defense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ LB Caleb Woodson	Virginia Tech	● ↑ Current reporting identifies him as the linebacker anchor.
◆ DL Terrance Green	Oregon	● ↔ Projects atop the nose/interior role and supplies needed mass/experience after major front departures.
◆ DL Devan Thompkins	USC	● ↔ Expected to hold a major Bandit/front role with inside-outside versatility in Wommack's structure.

Out	To	Loss
DL LT Overton	NFL (Dallas), Round 5, No. 137	● ↓ A major 2025 front contributor leaves for the NFL as the line is rebuilt.
DL Tim Keenan III	NFL (L.A. Rams), Round 7, No. 232	● ↓ A veteran interior contributor exits, increasing the importance of transfer additions and London Simmons.
LB Deontae Lawson	NFL (Philadelphia), undrafted free agent	● ↓ The 2025 team-leading tackler leaves for the Philadelphia Eagles.
CB Domani Jackson	NFL (Green Bay), Round 6, No. 201	● ↓ A starting corner departs.
EDGE Qua Russaw	Ohio State	● ↓ A material edge contributor transfers to Ohio State, adding to front-seven turnover.

Defensive net: ● ↓ Likely modest regression in continuity but still the team's strongest side.

5. How They Play

Phase	Identity	What works	Main vulnerability
Offense	Grubb-called, pass-oriented offense built around named but unproven QB Keelon Russell.	WR Ryan Coleman-Williams and WR Lotzeir Brooks give QB Russell high-end targets; three OL jobs are settled.	Replacing the 2025 starting QB, lead back and multiple linemen while RB/WR availability remains fluid.
Defense	Wommack's third-year defense remains multiple and physically oriented.	SP+ defense No. 6 and an experienced secondary provide a strong floor.	The front seven replaces DL LT Overton, DL Tim Keenan III, LB Deontae Lawson and EDGE Qua Russaw.
Special teams	The least settled phase, with all three specialist jobs open.	K Lorcan Quinn has Lou Groza watchlist recognition.	Kicker, punter and long snapper remain open; SP+ special teams is No. 109.

6. Unit Grades

Unit	Grade	vs. 2025	Confidence	Why
QB	● B-	● ↓	Medium-low	QB Keelon Russell won the job but remains unproven as a starter
RB	● B-	● ↓	Medium-low	RB Jam Miller departs and early availability reduces backfield certainty
WR	● B+	● ↔	Medium	WR Ryan Coleman-Williams and WR Lotzeir Brooks give the new QB proven targets
TE	● C+	● ↓	Low	The room replaces proven 2025 production with less established roles
OL	● B-	● ↓	Medium-low	C Racin Delgatty won center, but LG and RT remain open after major departures
DL/Edge	● B+	● ↓	Medium	DL Terrance Green and DL Devan Thompkins help replace major front losses
LB	● B	● ↓	Medium	LB Caleb Woodson anchors a group replacing LB Deontae Lawson
Secondary	● A-	● ↔	Medium-high	S Bray Hubbard and CB Zabien Brown headline the defense's most stable unit
Special teams	● C+	● ↓	Low	All three specialist jobs remain open despite K Lorcan Quinn's recognition
Coaching	● A-	● ↔	High	Kalen DeBoer, Ryan Grubb and Kane Wommack provide staff continuity
Overall	● B+	● ↓	Medium-low	Top-15 quality with contender-level defense and meaningful offensive transition risk

7. Players to Know

Recognition status: official conference honors and major award watchlists through Aug. 23, 2026.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
Bray Hubbard	S	● National star / defensive centerpiece	AP first team · Walter Camp second team · SEC Coaches first team · SEC Media first team	The safest elite player signal on the roster.
Zabien Brown	CB	● National high-end starter	AP second team · SEC Coaches first team · SEC Media first team · Bednarik Award	Returns as a top outside corner and pairs with S Bray Hubbard to give the secondary proven star power.
Ryan Coleman-Williams	WR	● High-end SEC starter / primary-target candidate	SEC Media first team · SEC Coaches second team · Biletnikoff Award · Maxwell Award	One of two established starting receivers.
Keelon Russell	QB	● Unproven starting quarterback / high-leverage projection	-	Won the starting job Aug. 22; his performance is Alabama's largest offensive variable.
Michael Carroll	OL	● High-end SEC interior starter	SEC Coaches second team · SEC Media second team · Outland Trophy	The most recognized settled lineman in a unit replacing multiple NFL/transfer veterans.
◆ Caleb Woodson (TR: Virginia Tech)	LB	● Transfer anchor / high-upside starter	Butkus Award	Virginia Tech transfer already identified as the current linebacker anchor.
Yhonzae Pierre	EDGE	● High-end SEC edge projection	SEC Coaches third team · SEC Media third team · Bednarik Award	Recognition gives Alabama a returning/continuity edge presence while several major front players depart.
◆ Devan Thompkins (TR: USC)	DL	● Transfer starter / versatile front piece	-	USC transfer is expected in a major Bandit role.

8. Schedule

Item	Assessment
Overall	Hard and top-heavy. Alabama has a manageable opening runway, but Georgia, Tennessee, Texas A&M and LSU create a concentrated championship-level stress test.
Difficulty	● 8/10 · SP+ SOS No. 17
Hardest stretch	Georgia -> at Tennessee -> Texas A&M
Swing games	at Tennessee, Texas A&M, at LSU, South Carolina
Advantage	The first five games contain only one SP+ top-25 opponent, and the bye falls between Texas A&M and the trip to LSU.
Expected	7.8 wins · likely 8-4
Floor / ceiling	6-6 / 10-2

9. Betting Lens

Angle	Read
Market posture	No. 13 AP and SP+ status should keep Alabama priced as an elite-brand team.
Back them when	The price is modest and the matchup allows the secondary/defense to dictate.
Fade/pass when	Asked to lay a premium against a strong front before QB Keelon Russell, the rebuilt OL and early RB rotation prove they can sustain offense.
Key monitor	QB Russell efficiency, LG/RT winners, AK Dear return, WR Noah Rogers game availability, front-seven replacement quality, specialist winners
Week 1 baseline	Alabama -22.0 vs. East Carolina - Alabama primer +17.5 minus East Carolina SP+ -2.3 plus 2.0 home field = 21.8, rounded to -22.0. East Carolina is a non-project FBS opponent. Live market: Alabama -28.5 (CBS Sports, Aug. 25).

10. Summary

Alabama remains a top-15 team because its defensive ceiling is high and the staff/receiver core gives QB Keelon Russell a workable launch point. The major question is how quickly a 35%-returning offense replaces its starting QB, lead back and multiple linemen.

The baseline is 7.8 wins and 8-4 against SP+ SOS No. 17. That projection leaves contender upside, but the new QB/OL/RB structure must earn trust before Alabama merits an automatic brand-name premium.

About this primer

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Sources: [OL update](#) · [NFL departures](#) · [Reuters report](#) · [DL update](#) · [2026 Alabama defensive backs position preview](#) · [2025 stats](#) · [camp update](#) · [camp update](#) · [2026 Alabama special teams position preview](#) · [QB update](#)

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